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📋 Free DIY SEO Checklist

Your complete step-by-step guide to optimizing your website for search engines

✅ SETUP & FOUNDATION (Week 1)

Google Tools Setup

- [ ] Create/claim Google Search Console account
- [ ] Verify website ownership in Search Console
- [ ] Set up Google Analytics (GA4)
- [ ] Link Google Analytics to Search Console
- [ ] Create/claim Google Business Profile
- [ ] Verify Google Business Profile

Technical SEO Audit

- [ ] Test mobile-friendliness (Google Mobile Test)
- [ ] Check page speed (aim for 80+ on PageSpeed)
- [ ] Verify HTTPS is active
- [ ] Create/verify XML sitemap exists
- [ ] Submit sitemap to Search Console
- [ ] Create robots.txt file
- [ ] Check for crawl errors

🔍 KEYWORD RESEARCH (Week 2)

Find Keywords

- [ ] Brainstorm 5-10 seed keywords
- [ ] Use Google autocomplete for long-tail ideas
- [ ] Check "People also ask" boxes
- [ ] Use AnswerThePublic for questions
- [ ] Review Search Console Performance report
- [ ] Identify 10-20 target keywords

Analyze Competition

- [ ] Google your target keywords
- [ ] Analyze top 10 results
- [ ] Identify content gaps
- [ ] Note search intent for each keyword

📝 ON-PAGE SEO (Week 3)

Homepage Optimization

- [ ] Title tag includes primary keyword (50-60 chars)
- [ ] Meta description is compelling (150-160 chars)
- [ ] URL is clean and descriptive
- [ ] H1 tag includes primary keyword
- [ ] Keyword appears in first 100 words
- [ ] Images have descriptive alt text

- [ ] Internal links to important pages

Service/Product Pages (Repeat for Each)

- [ ] Unique title tag with target keyword
- [ ] Unique meta description
- [ ] Content is 500+ words
- [ ] Images optimized with alt text
- [ ] Clear call-to-action (CTA)

Blog Posts

- [ ] Title includes target keyword
- [ ] Use H2/H3 subheadings throughout
- [ ] 1,500+ words for competitive topics
- [ ] 2-5 internal links to related content
- [ ] 1-3 external links to authoritative sources

🏠 LOCAL SEO (For Local Businesses)

Google Business Profile

- [ ] Profile is 100% complete
- [ ] NAP (Name, Address, Phone) accurate
- [ ] Primary category selected
- [ ] 10+ high-quality photos uploaded
- [ ] Services list is complete
- [ ] Respond to all reviews

Local Citations & Reviews

- [ ] NAP consistent across all platforms
- [ ] Listed on Yelp, Bing Places, Apple Maps
- [ ] Listed in industry directories
- [ ] Ask 5-10 customers for Google reviews
- [ ] Respond to reviews within 24-48 hours

📊 TECHNICAL SEO (Week 4)

Site Speed Optimization

- [ ] Compress images (TinyPNG)
- [ ] Enable browser caching
- [ ] Minimize CSS/JavaScript
- [ ] Use CDN if needed

Mobile & Structure

- [ ] Site is responsive on all devices
- [ ] Text readable without zooming
- [ ] Important pages within 3 clicks
- [ ] Fix broken links (404 errors)

✍️ CONTENT STRATEGY (Month 2+)

- [ ] Create content calendar (1-2 posts/week)
- [ ] Plan 3-5 pillar posts (2,000+ words)
- [ ] Plan 10+ supporting posts (cluster content)
- [ ] Write for humans first, search engines second
- [ ] Answer the searcher's question completely
- [ ] Target one primary keyword per page

🔗 LINK BUILDING (Month 2+)

- [ ] Create link-worthy resources (guides, tools)
- [ ] Build citations in 10-20 directories
- [ ] Reach out for 5 guest post opportunities
- [ ] Partner with complementary businesses
- [ ] Check backlinks monthly in Search Console

📈 TRACKING & REPORTING

Weekly Check-In

- [ ] Review organic traffic in Analytics
- [ ] Check Search Console for new keywords
- [ ] Monitor top-performing pages

Monthly Review

- [ ] Track keyword rankings
- [ ] Review backlink growth
- [ ] Identify optimization opportunities
- [ ] Update old content

🎯 90-DAY QUICK START PLAN

Month 1: Setup tools → Keyword research → Optimize top pages → Publish 2 pillar posts

Month 2: Publish 8 blog posts → Build 10+ citations → Request reviews → Guest post outreach

Month 3: Continue 2 posts/week → Update old content → Build 5-10 backlinks → Monitor & adjust

🚫 AVOID THESE MISTAKES

- [ ] ❌ Don't keyword stuff — use keywords naturally
- [ ] ❌ Don't publish thin content (<300 words)
- [ ] ❌ Don't ignore mobile users
- [ ] ❌ Don't buy backlinks — earn them
- [ ] ❌ Don't expect overnight results (SEO takes 3-6 months)

🛠️ RECOMMENDED FREE TOOLS

SEO Research

- Google Search Console
- Google Analytics (GA4)
- Google Keyword Planner
- AnswerThePublic

Technical SEO

- Google Mobile-Friendly Test
- PageSpeed Insights
- Screaming Frog (free 500 URLs)

Content

- Grammarly (free)
- Hemingway Editor
- Canva

Backlinks

- Search Console (backlinks)
- Google Alerts (mentions)

📥 **NEED MORE HELP?**
Read our complete guide: DIY SEO Guide for Small Business Owners
Get our templates: SEO Audit Template Bundle ($27)

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